Main Branches of Anthropology

1. Four fields, shared questions

Branch	Core concern	Main evidence / method
Socio-cultural	Social relationships, institutions, meanings and cultural change.	Ethnography, participant observation, interviews, surveys and archives.
Biological / physical	Human evolution, biological variation, growth and adaptation.	Fossils, anatomy, genetics, physiology and primate observation.
Archaeological	Past human life through material remains and context.	Survey, excavation, dating, artefact/environmental analysis.
Linguistic	Language, communication, thought, identity and social life.	Recorded speech, interaction/discourse analysis, comparison and fieldwork.

Applied anthropology spans these fields: research used in health, development, heritage, conservation, forensic work and policy. The fields overlap; bioarchaeology, for example, connects human remains with archaeological context.

2. Socio-cultural anthropology

Studies society and culture holistically: beliefs, values, customs, traditions, kinship, economy, politics and institutions in relation to one another.

- **Methods:** sustained fieldwork, participant observation, interviews, surveys and archival research; language competence deepens interpretation.
- **Questions:** How are resources shared? How is authority legitimised? How are identities learned and contested? What changes with migration, climate or development?
- **Applications:** assess displacement and development; support community-defined priorities; understand poverty, inequality and conflict.

Subfields and answer cues

Subfield	Focus	Illustrative question
Economic	Livelihoods, production, exchange and consumption.	How do gifts and reciprocal obligations organise resources?
Political	Power, leadership, governance and conflict.	How is authority recognised beyond formal office?
Kinship	Descent, marriage, family and relatedness.	Who gains rights to land, care or inheritance?
Religion	Belief, ritual and symbolic practice.	How does ritual relate to social identity?

Subfield	Focus	Illustrative question
Gender	Gendered roles, relations and power.	How are work and decision-making distributed?
Medical	Health, illness and care in cultural/social context.	How do trust and stigma influence care-seeking?
Urban	City life, migration, neighbourhoods and institutions.	How do migrants maintain or remake social networks?

Thinker → emphasis

- **Malinowski:** interconnected institutions and intensive fieldwork.
- **Radcliffe-Brown:** social structure and relations.
- **Lévi-Strauss:** structural relationships underlying cultural systems and classifications.
- **Clifford Geertz:** interpretation of meanings and symbols.
- **Margaret Mead:** variation in socialisation, adolescence and gender.
- **D. N. Majumdar and S. C. Dube:** Indian communities understood in their social/cultural setting.

These are **revision paraphrases**, not authenticated verbatim definitions.

Ethnography, ethnology and social anthropology

Term	What it does	Example
Ethnography	Contextual research and its written/other representation, grounded in sustained engagement with a particular setting.	Study a Mongolian pastoral community through herding activities, interviews and ritual observation.
Ethnology	Comparative/synthetic analysis of cultures using ethnographic and other evidence.	Compare gift exchange or kinship systems across several societies.
Social anthropology	Explains social relationships and institutions, often using ethnography and comparison.	Examine how kinship shapes access to coastal fishing resources.

- **Ethnography generates contextual accounts; ethnology compares; social anthropology investigates social organisation.** All can involve description, theory and interpretation.
- Ethnography is not mechanically “only descriptive”; comparison is not restricted to ethnology. British social and American cultural traditions differ historically, but overlap extensively today.

Why early anthropology emphasised “primitive societies”

- **Historical setting:** late-nineteenth/early-twentieth-century colonial expansion; evolutionists such as **Morgan and Tylor** imagined a universal ladder of development.
- **Salvage anthropology:** documentation of languages and practices believed to be disappearing under colonial contact and change.
- **Contributions:** rich ethnographic records; comparative evidence on kinship, religion and institutions; later contextual approaches associated with **Boas** challenged ethnocentrism.

- **Limitations:** living communities treated as survivals of Europe's past; cultures portrayed as isolated/static; romanticisation and research serving colonial power; inadequate attention to voices, rights and agency.
- **Contemporary position:** study all societies, including cities, migration and global networks; work collaboratively and recognise change, internal diversity and community priorities.

Do not equate "prehistoric" with living Indigenous communities. Prehistoric refers to a relation to written records; "primitive" is a historical and often derogatory label, not a biological rank or a reliable measure of complexity. Cultural relativism aids understanding without excusing harm.

3. Biological / physical anthropology

A biocultural, evolutionary study of humans and their relatives: origins, variation, inheritance, growth, health and environmental adaptation.

Area	Scope and methods	Recall example
Palaeoanthropology	Fossils, teeth, comparative anatomy, dating and genetic evidence reconstruct human evolution.	Australopithecus and early Homo; changes in locomotion and anatomy.
Primatology	Behaviour, ecology, anatomy and genetics of primates; field and laboratory studies.	Social organisation and cognition; compare with humans without treating living apes as human ancestors.
Human biology / variation	Population variation, growth/development, physiology and environmental responses.	Skin pigmentation, nutrition and high-altitude adaptation.
Human genetics	Genes, inheritance, population relationships, migration and disease-related variation.	Combine genetic findings with environmental/cultural context.
Forensic anthropology	Human skeletal evidence in legal identification and trauma investigation.	Estimate age/sex/stature and assess trauma with uncertainty; not every cause of death can be established from bones.
Bioarchaeology	Human remains interpreted within archaeological/social context.	Past diet, disease, mobility, demography and unequal life conditions.
Health and nutrition	Biological and cultural determinants of growth and health.	Food access, childhood growth and the effects of inequality.

Methods: field observation, anthropometry, laboratory genetics/physiology, skeletal analysis and fossil study. Primatology and conservation connect human research with the wider living world.

Classical and new physical anthropology

Dimension	Classical tendency	New physical anthropology
Main question	Describe/classify bodily differences, often into racial types.	Explain population variation and evolutionary processes.

Dimension	Classical tendency	New physical anthropology
Evidence	Anthropometry, craniometry and osteology; limited fossil evidence.	Population genetics, evolutionary synthesis, ecology, physiology and expanded fossil data.
Model	Often typological/static; racial ranking occurred in influential traditions.	Population-based, dynamic and biocultural.
Qualification	Measurement itself is not obsolete.	New techniques do not automatically remove bias; sampling, consent and interpretation matter.

- Developed especially around the **mid-twentieth century**, alongside population genetics and the modern evolutionary synthesis.
- **Human variation does not form a ladder of superior/inferior races.** Study ancestry, populations, environment and social histories without treating racial categories as fixed biological essences.

Scholars and contributions

Scholar	Safe association
Franz Boas	Human variation, growth and environmental influences; critique of racial determinism. Especially associated with founding American anthropology; “father” labels are context-dependent.
Earnest A. Hooton	Physical anthropology, skeletal variation and human evolution; racial/criminal-typological claims need historical criticism.
William W. Howells	Human evolution and quantitative study of cranial/population variation; not simply reducible to population genetics.
Don Brothwell (1933–2016)	Human skeletal remains, palaeopathology, past health and human ecology. University of York.
C. Owen Lovejoy	Hominin anatomy and locomotor biomechanics, especially bipedality. The source's death date “2000” is incorrect. Kent State profile.

4. Archaeological anthropology

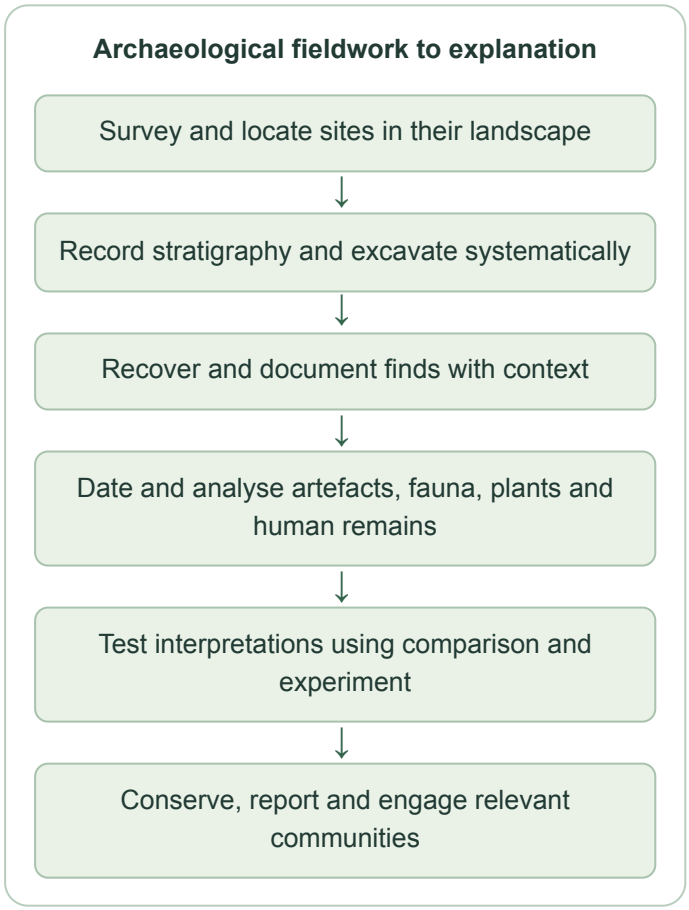
Reconstructs and explains human life through material remains: artefacts, buildings, tools, pottery, bones, plant remains, landscapes and **middens** (refuse deposits).

- **Nature:** interdisciplinary; anthropology joins geology, chemistry, biology and environmental studies. Context and association are essential.
- **Temporal reach:** prehistoric through historical and relatively recent societies. Written evidence complements rather than eliminates archaeology.
- **Aims:** reconstruct past lifeways; explain change and variation; relate past processes to present questions; protect heritage and examine whose past is represented.

Scope and themes

Area	Focus
Prehistoric archaeology	Societies without usable contemporary written records.
Historical archaeology	Material evidence interpreted alongside documents and other records.
Underwater archaeology	Submerged sites, shipwrecks and associated material; specialised recording/recovery.
Cultural resource management (CRM)	Identify, assess and protect heritage threatened by construction or other change.
Experimental archaeology	Replicate processes to test interpretations of manufacture, use and preservation.
Bioarchaeology	Human remains, health, diet, demography and social conditions.

Key themes: **cultural change; trade/contact/diffusion; settlement patterns; art/ritual/symbolism; human–environment relations**. Similar-looking objects do not alone establish the same cultural meaning.



Old, new and later interpretive approaches

Approach	Emphasis	Qualification
Traditional / culture-historical	Description, classification, chronology and reconstruction of cultural sequences.	Not every earlier archaeologist accepted a single unilinear evolution model.

Approach	Emphasis	Qualification
New Archaeology / processual, especially 1960s	Explain processes; explicit hypotheses, systems/ecology, quantitative analysis and testing.	Interpretation still depends on sampling, preservation and assumptions.
Later post-processual approaches	Meaning, agency, power, identity and the researcher's standpoint.	Not synonymous with processual “New Archaeology”; different approaches can inform one investigation.

Scholar → contribution

- **V. Gordon Childe:** Neolithic/Urban Revolutions, technology and social transformation; bridges description and explanation.
- **Lewis Binford:** processual archaeology, scientific explanation and links between observable remains and past behaviour—not merely “understand the present”.
- **James Deetz:** historical archaeology, everyday material culture and meaning; do not reduce him to one theoretical label.
- **Timothy Earle:** complex societies, political economy, inequality and political power.
- **H. D. Sankalia and B. N. Misra:** important Indian prehistoric field research, including central Indian sites such as Bhimbetka/Adamgarh in the wider research tradition.
- **N. K. Bose:** major Indian social/cultural anthropologist; not interchangeable with the prehistoric archaeologists above.
- **Ruth Benedict:** culture-and-personality/*Patterns of Culture*; the source incorrectly places her among archaeological theorists. Columbia University.

India's early hominin evidence, including the Narmada fossil, matters to evolutionary research; it does not establish India as an independent origin point of all modern humans or settle every fossil's species attribution.

5. Linguistic anthropology

Studies language as cultural practice and social action: how people communicate, construct identities and meanings, and reproduce or challenge relationships.

- **Language ↔ culture:** each influences the other; study speech in actual settings.
- **Communication and interaction:** conversation, discourse, face-to-face cues, social relationships and institutional settings.
- **Cognition:** acquisition, categorisation, meaning and the relationship between language and thought.

Area	Main question
Sociolinguistics	How does language vary with class, gender, ethnicity, identity and situation?
Ethnolinguistics	How does language express cultural categories, values and ritual meanings?
Discourse analysis	How does connected language create meaning, accomplish goals and negotiate relations?
Cognitive linguistics	How are language, conceptualisation and mental processes related?

Area	Main question
Historical linguistics	How do languages change, relate and form language families?

Scholar → concept

Scholar	Recall
Franz Boas	Documentation of Indigenous North American languages and attention to language/culture.
Edward Sapir	Language, culture and linguistic variation; associated with linguistic relativity.
Benjamin Lee Whorf	Linguistic categories and habitual thought/perception.
Dell Hymes	Ethnography of speaking; speech events and socially situated communicative competence.
John J. Gumperz (1922–2013)	Interactional sociolinguistics and **contextualisation cues**; corrects the source's “1927–2022”. University of California memorial.

Sapir–Whorf caution: linguistic relativity explores influences on habitual thought; it is not proof that language rigidly determines everything a speaker can think. The label brings together related ideas rather than one jointly written formula.

Application: language documentation, migrant communication, education, legal/medical encounters and understanding misunderstandings across speech communities.

6. Mains questions and answer cues

Year / marks	Question focus	Build the answer around
2023 · 10 · about 150 words	Scope and relevance of Social and Cultural Anthropology	Definition; institutions/meaning/change; fieldwork; development/health/migration; ethical relevance.
2022 · 20	“Anthropology is the systematic, objective and holistic study of human kind in all times and places”. Elaborate the argument.	Systematic evidence; reflexive objectivity; four-field integration; comparison across time/space; limitations and application.
2019 · 10 · about 150 words	Relationship between Linguistics and Social-Cultural Anthropology	Language as social action; identity/kinship/ritual; ethnography; Sapir, Hymes, Gumperz; avoid determinism.
2018 · 15	Field methods in Archaeological Anthropology	Survey, excavation, stratigraphy, contextual recording, sampling, dating, environmental analysis, conservation and ethics.
2016 · 10 · about 150 words	Differences between Social Anthropology and Sociology	Traditional focus/method contrasts and present convergence; Chapter 2 comparison.

Year / marks	Question focus	Build the answer around
2015 · 10 · about 150 words	Archaeological Anthropology	Definition; material evidence/context; temporal scope; methods; explanation and heritage.
2013 · 10 · about 150 words	Linguistic Anthropology	Language/culture; variation and interaction; field methods; application.
1994 · 10 · about 150 words	Social and Cultural Anthropology	Social relationships and cultural meanings; overlap, methods and example.
1990 · 10 · about 150 words	Applied Anthropology	Research for practical problems; cross-field examples; consent and community agency.
1989 · 10 · about 150 words	Theme of Linguistic Anthropology	Language, thought, culture and social interaction.
1989 · 10 · about 150 words	New Physical Anthropology	Population approach, genetics/evolution, ecology and biocultural explanation versus racial typology.

The older questions' marks/word limits follow the supplied chapter where original papers are unavailable; verified recent questions use official wording and marks in the common bank.

7. Last-minute recall

- **Ethnography = contextual account; ethnology = comparison; social anthropology = relationships/institutions.**
- **Classical physical = description/types; new physical = populations/processes.**
- **Old archaeology = classification/sequence; processual = explanation/testing; post-processual = meaning/agency/power.**
- **Boas—context; Malinowski—fieldwork; Radcliffe-Brown—structure; Geertz—meaning.**
- **Childe—revolutions; Binford—processual; Hymes—speaking; Gumperz—contextualisation.**